

ILLUSTRATION: N. S. SINGH



Stepping Off the Gas

HYDERABAD The Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas claims there is no shortage of cooking gas, but housewives across the country beg to disagree. Eleven states are reeling under severe shortages, indicative of a deepening crisis and the ministry has asked the public sector oil companies to increase supplies.

With the cooking gas crisis likely to emerge as a political issue with the Lok Sabha polls just a year

away, Petroleum and Natural Gas Minister Murli Deora has even persuaded oil companies to make an additional import of nearly 30 million tonnes of liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) to overcome the shortage. Panic bookings for gas refills following reports of a proposed hike in LPG prices and its diversion for commercial and heating purposes, because of an extended winter, have led to the shortage.

KITCHEN WOES: LPG shortage has hit homes

Oil companies are producing 11 to 12 per cent more LPG this year and imports are likely to cross 2.25 million tonnes in 2007-08 as against 1.92 million tonnes in the last financial year. LPG consumption during April-December 2007 was up 10.2 per cent to 8.75 million tonnes compared to the corresponding period in the previous year.

To check the diversion of subsidised domestic cooking gas to hotels and commercial establishments, the Government has introduced the system of providing refills to a household once in every 21 days. Requests for refills are accepted only after 21 days from the previous delivery. No less aggravating is the fact that the LPG quota regime introduced during 2005 saves hardly Rs 300 crore for the exchequer and has brought with it bad publicity for the Government. Not a particularly good omen on the eve of an election year.

by Amarnath K. Menon

SIGNPOSTS

CONFERRED: On singer, musician, filmmaker and lyricist **Bhupen Hazarika**, the Pramathesh Chandra Baruah lifetime achievement award by the Assam Government.



WON: By Shiv Shankar Prasad Chowrasia, 29, the Indian Masters at the Delhi

Golf Club, his first European Tour win. He bagged Rs 1.6 crore as prize money.

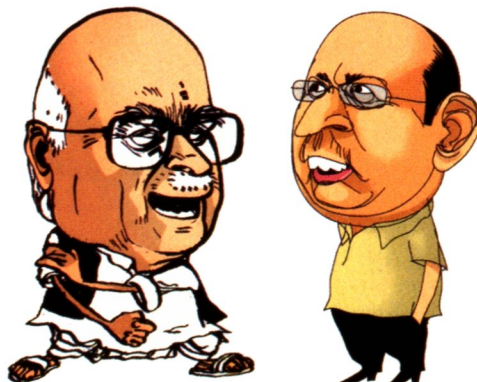
DIED: Madhya Pradesh Education Minister **Laxman Singh Gaud**, in a road accident in Dewas.

SELECTED: Professor **Santanu Bhattacharya**, for the G.D. Birla Award for Scientific Research for his contribution to chemical biology and molecular design.

ARRESTED: **Pulakesh Baruah**, former Speaker of the Assam Assembly, in connection with a case of illegal appointment of teachers in Nalbari.

VIS-A-VIS **L.K. ADVANI** Leader of the Opposition **versus** **ABHISHEK MANU SINGHVI** Congress spokesperson

The Congress is both unable and unwilling to tackle jihadi terrorism because of its vote-bank politics.



SAURABH SINGH

Advani has created a climate of insecurity. Is he concerned about the nation or about politicking?

EPILOGUE: National security is an issue leaders should abstain from politicking about.